

THE DOLPHIN

Delphinus



SIZE RANKING 69

BRIGHTEST STAR
Rotanev (β) 3.6

GENITIVE Delphini

ABBREVIATION Del

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
August–SeptemberFULLY VISIBLE
90°N–69°S

This small but distinctive constellation is situated between Aquila and Pegasus. According to Greek myth, Delphinus represents the dolphin that saved the poet and musician Arion from drowning after he leaped into the sea to escape robbers onboard a ship. Alternatively, the constellation is said to depict one of the dolphins sent by Poseidon to bring the sea nymph Amphitrite to him to marry. It is one of the constellations listed by the astronomer Ptolemy (see p.347).

The whole constellation was once popularly known as Job's Coffin, presumably because of the boxlike shape of its area, although sometimes this name is restricted to the diamond asterism formed by the four brightest

GAMMA DELPHINI ♂

Gamma (γ) Delphini is an attractive double star. Although both the component stars are usually described as yellow, some observers see the fainter star as bluish.

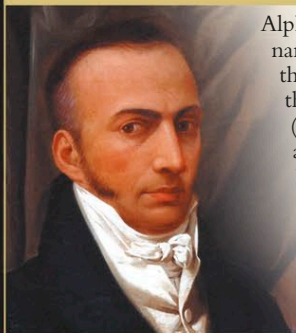
stars: Sualocin (α), Rotanev (β), and Gamma (γ) and Delta (δ) Delphini. Who coined the name Job's Coffin and when is not known.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

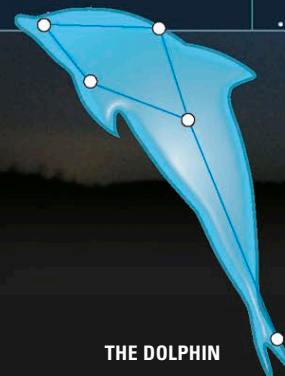
Gamma (γ) Delphini is normally described as an attractive orange-yellow double star. Its components are of 4th and 5th magnitudes, and they are easily separated by a small telescope.

The fainter and closer double star Struve 2725, which has components of 7th and 8th magnitudes, can also be seen through a small telescope and is visible in the same field of view as Gamma (γ) Delphini.

NICCOLÒ CACCIATORE



Alpha (α) and Beta (β) Delphini bear the unusual names Sualocin and Rotanev. When reversed, these names spell Nicolaus Venator. This is the Latinized name of Niccolò Cacciatore (1780–1841), an Italian astronomer who was assistant to Giuseppe Piazzi, the director of the Palermo Observatory, Sicily. Cacciatore defied convention by surreptitiously naming two stars after himself in the Palermo star catalog of 1814. No one realized what he had done until much later, by which time the star names had become established.



THE DOLPHIN

THE PLAYFUL DOLPHIN 🐬

The kite-shaped Delphinus, on the edge of the Milky Way near Cygnus, brings to mind a dolphin jumping from ocean waters.

THE FOAL

Equuleus



SIZE RANKING 87

BRIGHTEST STAR
Alpha (α) 3.9

GENITIVE Equulei

ABBREVIATION Equ

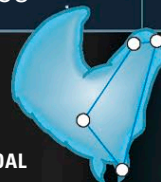
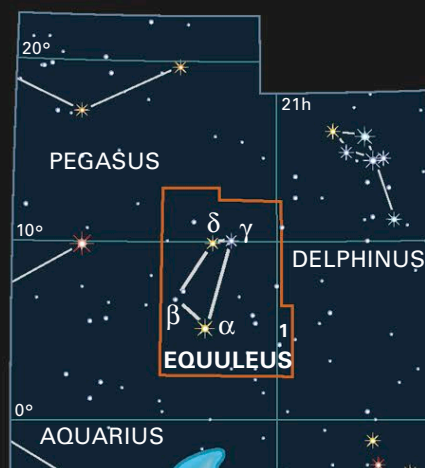
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
SeptemberFULLY VISIBLE
90°N–77°S

The second-smallest constellation in the sky represents the head of a young horse, or foal, and lies next to the larger celestial horse, Pegasus. No myths or legends are associated with Equuleus, which is thought to have

been added to the sky by the Greek astronomer Ptolemy in his 2nd-century-CE compendium of the original Greek constellations.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Gamma (γ) Equulei is a wide double star with components of 5th and 6th magnitudes and is easily separated with binoculars. Its two stars are unrelated. The 5th-magnitude double star 1 Equulei—labeled as Epsilon (ϵ) Equulei on some maps—has a 7th-magnitude companion, which can be seen through a small telescope, and a fainter true companion, which can be seen only through instruments with larger apertures. Other than these two double stars, there is nothing of note in Equuleus for users of binoculars or small telescopes.



THE FOAL

THE HORSE'S HEAD 🐎

Equuleus consists of a small area of faint stars wedged between Pegasus and Delphinus and is easily overlooked.